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Government data shows more than 12,000 Queensland teaching employees have quit since 2020



By Kenji Sato

By Steve Austin

612 ABC Brisbane

Education

Posted Tue 9 Apr 2024 at 4:17am, updated Tue 9 Apr 2024 at 4:17am



Queensland Education Minister Di Farmer reported the figures in parliament. (ABC Radio Brisbane: Kenji Sato)

In short:

At least 12,375 Queensland teacher and teacher aides have resigned since 2020.

Teacher Sue-Belinda Meehan says university graduates are not being equipped to handle real-world classrooms.

The Queensland government says it is on track to hire 6,100 new teachers and 1,100 new teacher aides since 2020.

Queensland's teaching workforce has reduced significantly over the past four years, according to government data, after more than 12,375 employees resigned.

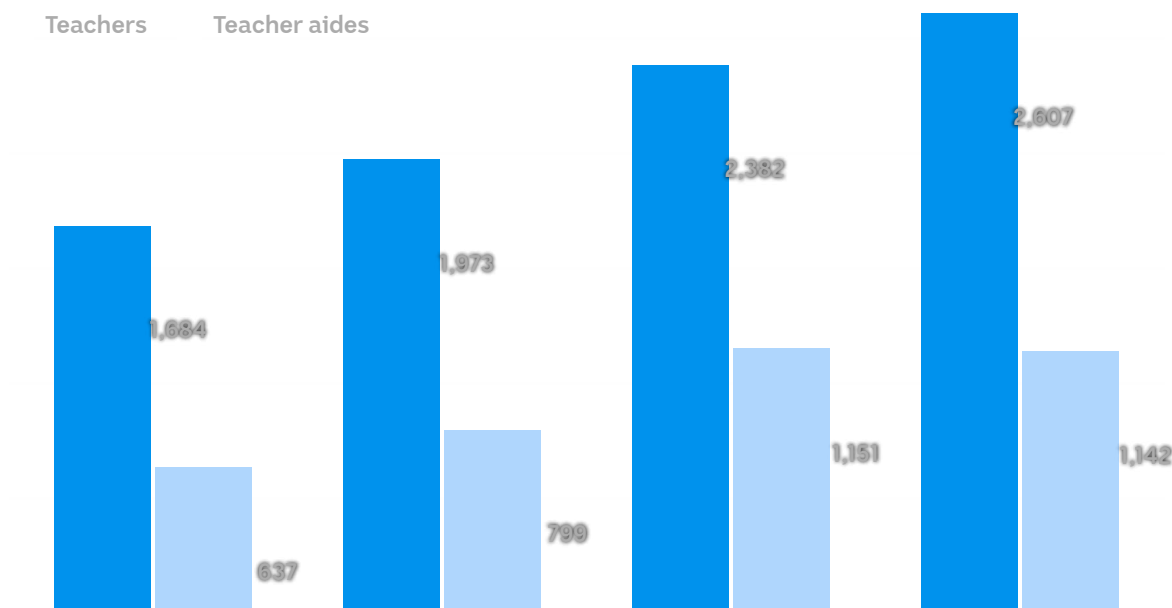
Queensland Education Minister Di Farmer told parliament that at least 8,646 teachers and 3,729 teacher aides had quit since 2020.

She said there was currently no departmental data on how many had resigned so far in 2024.

In 2020, the Queensland government vowed to hire 6,100 new teachers and 1,100 new teacher aides by the end of 2024.

At the time, former premier Anastacia Palaszczuk hailed the \$2.2 billion recruitment drive as the "single biggest investment" in teachers in Queensland history.

Queensland teacher resignations



2023

Kenji Sato / Source: Queensland Parliament Questions on Notice / [Get the data](#)

The Education Minister said they were on track to deliver their four-year hiring target, with 3,800 teaching roles already filled in 2023 alone.

Ms Farmer said some of the resignations were due to teacher aides changing roles and becoming teachers or departmental staff.

"We will continue to monitor trends in resignations within the Department of Education to ensure support services and training opportunities are fit for purpose," she said.

"Above all, we will ensure Queensland kids get the best education possible."

Ms Farmer said teacher retention rates were steady at 95 per cent.

Teachers quitting in 'alarming' numbers

Brisbane educator Sue-Belinda Meehan said she believed one of the reasons teachers were quitting in such "alarming" numbers was a lack of practical training.



Sue-Belinda Meehan says teaching graduates are not being equipped to handle real-world classroom. (ABC Radio Brisbane: Kenji Sato)

She said universities were not adequately teaching practical skills to handle real classroom scenarios, [such as bad behaviour](#) or special-needs students.

Ms Meehan became a teacher in the 1970s, back when most aspiring teachers went to state-run teachers' colleges instead of universities.

She said her teachers' college experience involved eight-hour days, 42 weeks per year, and practical classroom experience beginning from week two.

Ms Meehan said this was a far cry from university education degrees, which typically had far fewer face-to-face learning hours, practical experiences and professional mentors.

As a result, Ms Meehan said young teachers she spoke to often felt overwhelmed and unprepared when they faced a real classroom.

"You're just not getting the same depth of teacher education preparation that you got in the old days," she said.

"The thing I find really sad is often the young teachers we're losing are really harsh on themselves, who really want to teach."

Additionally, Ms Meehan said modern teachers had new challenges that did not exist when she first started.

Ms Meehan said teachers now had to deal with more paperwork, distracted students on phones and tablets, and worse levels of classroom behaviour.

Opposition education spokesperson Christian Rowan said the Queensland government was "not listening" to the needs of teachers.

He said teachers were dropping out of the workforce faster than they were being recruited.

"They're leaving because they're not being listened to, they're not being respected, they're not getting the resources that they need," Dr Rowan said.

"It's no wonder then that literacy and numeracy outcomes in Queensland continue to decline."

A meaningful career

Ms Meehan said if young teachers were able to overcome the challenges of the job, a truly rewarding career was awaiting them.

"There's nothing in this world as good as watching a child, who comes into your classroom and they can't read, suddenly making meaning, doing all these high order things, and you had a hand at it," she said.

"On those days it's so fabulous you feel like you could almost give them the money back."



Christian Rowan says Queensland has been failing its literacy and numeracy targets for some year levels. (Supplied: Twitter)

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